

How Woolf and Rhys use Modernist technique to show what it costs to be a woman

After reading books of Both Virginia Woolf's *To the Lighthouse* and Jean Rhys's *Wide Sargasso Sea* I came to conclusion that they are centered with the same question of what is actually going on inside a woman's head, and what does the world around her do to it? They answer that question using modernist techniques in their books, mainly stream of consciousness flowing into each paragraph and interior monologue that let us live inside characters rather than watch them from the outside. But the two novels are not simply doing the same thing. Woolf gives us Mrs. Ramsay, a woman who has chosen, or been shaped into choosing, to pour her kindness into other people, and Rhys gives us Antoinette, a woman who never got to choose anything at all. Both of them are destroyed by the same structure: a world that turns women into domestic fixtures, beautiful and useful and finally invisible. But the way that destruction happened is completely different.

This essay argues that both novels use stream of consciousness to show that women's inner lives are being constantly invaded, managed, or erased by the people and spaces around them, and that the houses in each book are not just backgrounds but actual prisons: ones that the women have been taught to love.

Getting inside the head: What stream of consciousness actually showed to me

The most important thing stream of consciousness does in both novels is made me realize how much of what a woman thinks and feels is shaped by what other people expect her to think and feel.

In 'To the Lighthouse', one of the strangest and most revealing moments is when Mrs. Ramsay finally gets a second alone, with no one needing anything from her, and Woolf shows us what happens:

"To be silent; to be alone. All the being and the doing, expansive, glittering, vocal, evaporated; and one shrunk, with a sense of solemnity, to being oneself, a wedge-shaped core of darkness, something invisible to others... and this self having shed its attachments was free for the strangest adventures."

What's striking here is that Mrs. Ramsay's real self: Woolf calls 'a wedge-shaped core of darkness' only appears when she stops performing. The "being and doing," the charming, managing, smoothing over version of herself, is described as something that "evaporated." here she described her nearly fully. She has been shaped so much by the role of wife, mother, and social expectation of others that her actual self is almost formless as nothing, just darkness and silence. This is what the Angel in the House costed them: not just time and energy, but the self itself.

If Woolf had written Mrs. Ramsay on an external basis, we would have perceived her to be a very capable and attractive female managing her own household. But in order to fully appreciate and understand the exhaustion of a woman, the self-erasure and the peculiar sense of relief after being 'made invisible by others', we all must read the text with a view of each character's thinking in their innner selves.

Rhys uses similar way but with a different and more brutal outcome; for instance, in the first few pages of *Wide Sargasso Sea* I saw that Antoinette has a rich and, I should

mention, detailed interior voice that incorporates the physical features of Coulibri itself. Smells, colours and textures depicted from her domestic environment.

“There was never a time when I did not love the road from Coulibri. The sharp smell of bay leaves, the gentle curves of the hills, the smell of wood smoke... I knew it all.” (Wide Sargasso Sea)

At this point her identity is inseparable from place. She knows herself through the landscape. But this is precisely what the novel then takes away from her so we can understand better. When Rochester takes over the narration in Part Two, we lose Antoinette’s voice entirely, and that is not accidental in my opinion. Because it mirrors what happens to her later on. His perspective flattens and misreads her, eventually renaming her. When he says: “Antoinette is not a name I will use”, and this is one of the most chilling lines in the book because we have been immersed in the consciousness of Antoinette. Rochester did not only change her name; he changed her name within the context of the story itself.

So in both cases, the stream of consciousness is not just showing what the characters are thinking rather it is showing what it looks like when someone else gets to decide what a woman is. Woolf shows a woman who has partly consented to that process; Rhys shows one who never had the option.

The “Angel” in the house and what it actually does to a person

In my opinion The Victorian times ideal of the woman: “Angel in the House” the selfless and endlessly giving, emotionally devoted wife and mother moves both novels as a kind of ghost. In ‘To the Lighthouse’, Mrs. Ramsay is that angel. In Wide Sargasso Sea, Antoinette is what happens to a woman, ideal was never even offered to.

Mrs. Ramsay is genuinely extraordinary at the “Angel” role. The dinner party scene in the middle of Part One is the clearest example: she takes a group of people who have been snapping at each other all day, her husband’s irritability, Tansley’s rudeness, Lily’s discomfort and through presence and attention she creates something beautiful in this situation:

“And she felt, with her hand on the door, that community of feeling with other people which emotion gives, as if the walls of partition had become so thin that practically it was one room...” (To The Lighthouse)

In this part Mrs. Ramsay created both real connection and warmth. The novel does not disapprove that. But Woolf also showed that this gift costs her everything. A few pages earlier, during the same dinner, she thought this about men:

“...she had the whole of the other sex under her protection; for reasons she could not explain, for their chivalry and valour, for the fact that they negotiated treaties, ruled India, controlled finance... she pitied men always as if they lacked something—lacked what she had.” (To The Lighthouse)

This passage is sad when I read it carefully . Here Mrs. Ramsay pitied men for their emotional incompetence and then spent her entire life compensating for it. She sees their lack, recognizes it as a lack, and then fills it anyway. That is the trap of the “Angel” ideal in one paragraph: the woman who can see exactly what is happening to her, and does it anyway, because she has been shaped to believe that filling the gap is her purpose.

Lily sees this clearly from the outside. When Tansley says that women can’t paint, can’t write, Mrs. Ramsay does not push back herself from the situation rather she manages the situation and keeps things going smoothly just like filling the gap, protects Tansley’s dignity at

the cost of Lily's. In turn, Lily feels the insult, resists internally but also finds herself pulled toward Mrs. Ramsay's world of self-sacrifice: "The Ramsays' happiness. It was distilled and filtered into her too.". Just like this the novel holds the beauty and the damage together without resolving them.

Now, In *Wide Sargasso Sea*, from what I see: "Angel" ideal operates as a weapon rather than a trap. Antoinette is a Creole woman, considered neither fully English nor belongs to the new Black community of Jamaica. Her only childhood friend Tia throws a stone at her and calls her "white cockroach" after Coulibri is burned. One stone thrown by the one person Antoinette loved captures her position perfectly that she belongs nowhere.

And later Rochester marries her and uses her racial and mental history real or invented, he doesn't really investigate to control her and eventually destroy her. He receives anonymous letters suggesting she is mad. His response is not concern as we see here:

"This is not a story I will tell, I thought. It's not mine to tell. But I have read about the Cosways. I know what she is."

He has already decided. The "Angel," as portrayed in Rhys's book, was just a social and class construct from the beginning. It was never meant for Antoinette. When she cannot perform it to Rochester's satisfaction, she becomes not a failed angel but a madwoman and the novel shows that those were always the only two options the patriarchal system made available.

What the houses do to them

So from my point of view both novels use their physical settings such as houses: as ways of showing mental states. But more than that, the houses in both books work as the material forms of the psychological cages.

The Ramsay family's summer house on Skye is established from the first page as emotional place as we can see the conversation with his son. It is where the children are happy, where Mrs. Ramsay is most completely herself or most completely her social self, which amounts to the same thing working as a gap filler. And just like that, all of it is connected to Mrs. Ramsay's presence. And that is the reason why "Time Passes", the short middle section of the novel is crucial. Mrs. Ramsay has died (mentioned in brackets, almost as an afterthought. As if individual's death is insignificant even-tough their significance is great) and Woolf describes the house without its mistress:

"...the swallows nested in the drawing room; the carpet was ruined... Tortoiseshell butterflies burst from the chrysalis and pattered their life out on the window-pane. Poppies sowed themselves among the dahlias..." (To The Lighthouse)

The house falls apart and nature takes it. Warmth, the order and the beauty Mrs. Ramsay maintained dissolves almost immediately without her. And what Woolf made me feel here is something uncomfortable: she entirely was spent on maintaining a house and the house couldn't even hold it for a decade. The domestic space was always her cage. The thing she was brilliant at and the thing that consumed her.

When Lily returns to the house in Part Three and tries to finish her painting, everything she sees is haunted by Mrs. Ramsay's presence. But Lily finished the painting without needing anyone's approval so we can understand that there is another way to be a woman. The lighthouse,

visible across the water throughout the whole novel and finally reached at the end and it is like to get somewhere you've been told is impossible.

Conclusion

What made both novels so powerful when read one after the other is that they showed me the same system doing its damage in completely different ways. Woolf shows a woman who was brilliant and given every advantage the system offered and still lost herself in it. And in *Wide Sargasso Sea*, a woman to whom the system offered nothing except the violence underneath its surface. Mrs. Ramsay disappears into the domestic ideal because she has mastered it; Antoinette disappears because she was never allowed to. The stream of consciousness technique, in both novels, is what made loss visible. The view of what it felt like to be inside it. The houses they lived in were never just houses. They were the shape their lives were allowed to take and the walls that kept them there as a golden cage.

Works Cited

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